5.6 Suppletion

Another important phenomenon that might be featured in linguistics problems is suppletion. This generally refers to the situation in which one stem (so one morpheme with a semantic component) has two or more completely different forms (in most cases due to different etymologies). Suppletion can be noticed to a lesser extent in most languages, including English (*good – better*, *bad – worse*, *go – went*), French (*être – sommes*, *aller – vais*), Spanish (*ir – voy*), German (*gut – besser*), etc. We can notice that, in each of the cases, it is not simply a mutation of the stem (as for example in English: *goose – geese* or *mouse – mice*), but rather the two forms are completely distinct.

This phenomenon seldom appears in linguistics problems, which makes it extremely hard to notice and, similar to the disfixes, it must be used with caution since there might only be some phonological transformations.

5.7 Expressing possession

A common way of marking possession in the world's languages is to use the genitive case. This is usually expressed by a morpheme attached to the noun (and, sometimes, its dependents) that functions as the possessor.

In certain languages, often ones belonging to the Austronesian family, possession can be marked by an affix or an independent word. In these cases, the word used is a classifier (similar to those defined above). Moreover, in a multitude of languages, there is a dichotomy between alienable and inalienable possession. *Inalienable* possession refers to those objects one owns and which cannot be borrowed/lent or taken (in most cases, they include body parts and family members), while *alienable* possession refers to all the other cases. In most languages where this distinction is relevant, inalienable possession is formed by attaching the possessor morpheme directly to the noun, while alienable possession is formed using possession classes.

Problem 5.6

Fijian (Viktoria Papp, UKLO 2018)

Here are some phrases in Fijian and their English translations:

1.	*na uluqu*	‘my head’
2.	*na nona wau*	‘her weapon (she owns)’
3.	*na memunī bia*	‘your$_{\text{PL}}$ beer’
4.	*na kemudrau itukutuku*	‘your$_{\text{DU}}$ story (about you two)’
5.	*na nona motokaa*	‘her car’
6.	*na meda tī*	‘our$_{\text{INCL}}$ tea’
7.	*na kelemu*	‘your$_{\text{SG}}$ belly’
8.	*na nona dio*	‘her oyster (she’ll sell)’
9.	*na kequ uvi*	‘my yam’
10.	*na noqu itukutuku*	‘my story (I tell)’
11.	*na watiqu*	‘my spouse’
12.	*na kemunī vuaka*	‘your$_{\text{PL}}$ pig (you’ll eat)’
13.	*na nomu kato*	‘your$_{\text{SG}}$ basket’
14.	*na tamana*	‘her father’
15.	*na memudrau dio*	‘your$_{\text{DU}}$ oyster (you’ll slurp)’
16.	*na nodra vuaka*	‘their pig (they raise)’
17.	*na keda wau*	‘our$_{\text{INCL}}$ weapon (we’ll be hit with)’
18.	*na kedra raisi*	‘their rice’

Problem 5.6a Now the Fijian words are given to you. Your task is to translate the phrase in the table into Fijian:

	Fijian	English	English phrase to translate
19.	*uto*	‘heart’	‘my heart’
20.	*yaqona*	‘kava’	‘her kava (she’s drinking)’
21.	*yaqona*	‘kava’	‘her kava (drunk in her honour)’
22.	*draunikau*	‘witchcraft’	‘my witchcraft (used on/against me)’
23.	*draunikau*	‘witchcraft’	‘your$_{\text{DU}}$ witchcraft (you’re making)’
24.	*dali*	‘rope’	‘your$_{\text{SG}}$ rope (you own)’
25.	*dali*	‘rope’	‘your$_{\text{PL}}$ rope (restraining you)’
26.	*ika*	‘fish’	‘your$_{\text{DU}}$ fish’
27.	*wai*	‘water’	‘your$_{\text{PL}}$ water’
28.	*luve*	‘child’	‘her child’
29.	*waqa*	‘canoe’	‘our$_{\text{INCL}}$ canoe’
30.	*yapolo*	‘apple’	‘their apple (they’ll sell)’
31.	*maqo*	‘mango’	‘their mango (for drinking)’

Problem 5.6b Explain your translation 21. (Why did you translate it this way?)

Problem 5.6c The word for 'coconut' is *niu*. List all the ways to say 'my coconut' and explain what they could mean.



'Weapon' refers to a club-like tool. A 'yam' is an edible starchy root. 'Kava' is a ceremonial drink.

The subscripts SG, DU, PL refer to singular (one person), dual (two persons), and plural (more than two persons), respectively. The subscript INCL means inclusive ('our$_{\text{INCL}}$' = belonging to me, you, and them, in contrast with 'our$_{\text{EXCL}}$' = belonging to me and them, but not you).

Solution

The first step we need to take is to determine the structure of the Fijian phrases. We can easily notice that all examples start with the word *na* followed by either one or two words. Separating the structures that contain a single word (i.e., the Fijian words for 'my head', 'your$_{\text{SG}}$ belly', 'my husband', 'her father'), we notice that all of them represent inalienable possessions. We therefore expect them to have the possessor marked directly on the noun, as an affix.

Indeed, comparing the structures 'my head' = *na uluqu* and 'my husband' = *na watiqu*, we discover that they both share the suffix *-qu*, which we then can deduce to mean 1SG possession. Therefore, for the inalienable possession, the phrase structure is *na* Noun–Poss.

In order to determine the structure of the rest of the phrases, we compare examples that contain the same noun (for example, 8 and 15, both containing the noun which means 'oyster'). We notice that both of them have the last word in common (*dio*), so the last word represents the noun, the possessed. Moreover, comparing examples 9 and 10 (both containing the possessive 'my'), we notice that they have in common the suffix *-qu* attached to the second word. Consequently, we can deduce that the structure of the alienable possession in Fijian is *na X*–Poss Noun. From here, we can easily determine the possession suffixes (applying similar processes as in Problem 5.5 where we had to separate the number from the classifier). We obtain: